

PTI

## Jemimah Rodrigues | 25 |

**Innings: 7; Runs: 292; Average: 58.4**

**Earlier this January, Jemimah was at DY Patil Stadium, jumping and swaying to Coldplay's 'Paradise' and 'Viva la Vida'. Little did she know that nine months later, she'd command the same stage—not as a fan, but as the rockstar of both the stadium and the nation—playing her most inspired innings, an unbeaten 127 against seven-time champions Australia, to carry India into the finals. That the innings came after being dropped mid-tournament made it all the more impressive. The squad's de facto cheerleader, one who strums the guitar in team hotels and makes the funniest reels with her teammates, Jemi, as she's popularly known, is much beloved. It was in her honest post-match interview that she added more to her fanbase. "I have almost cried every day through this tour," she admitted. "I was going through anxiety. I knew I had to show up and God took care of everything." It's in Jemimah that a nation now believes.**

Kranti Goud could play with the boys in her native Ghuwara in Chhattarpur, Madhya Pradesh, only because of her 'boy cut' hair. Others had the equivalent of a Mahavir Singh Phogat for fathers, who would go against the grain to support their sporting dreams. So, Amanjot's carpenter father would handcraft a bat for his daughter, while Harmanpreet's would buy his newborn girl a shirt saying, "Good batting", unknowingly sealing her fate. Jemimah Rodrigues's father was her first coach; Pratika Rawal's was a BCCI-certified umpire, and her biggest cheerleader accompanying her to academies and tournaments.

There were few female sporting icons to look up to, and if there were, they were restricted predominantly to individual disciplines like badminton, boxing and wrestling. In cricket, the heroes were mostly men: Kranti's was Hardik Pandya, while Shafali modelled her emphatic striking after Virender Sehwag. Very few, including big-city girl Jemimah, even knew of the existence of a women's cricket team. Nooshin Al-Khadeer, who was part of the historic team to play the 2005 World Cup finals, remembers being used to the none-too-benign neglect the women's team received. They had no sponsors, would often have to sleep in dormitories or on the ground, prepare pitches after sweeping the ground of pebbles and play to empty stadiums. There was no concept of match fee until the BCCI took charge of the women's game. "We had to pay from our pockets to play for India," says Edulji. Nooshin recalls how in 2005 they were paid Rs 8,000 for their efforts—Rs 1,000 per match played. Matches themselves were scanty. In fact,



***"Women's cricket has been on an upswing for a while. What's made a difference is that now they have been made to feel they are not just among the best but the best"***

**— SUNIL GAVASKAR**
*Cricketing legend*